YaapZone: how to release a new version

A step-by-step checklist. Follow it top to bottom every time. Each step shows exactly what to type and what you should see.

What a release does. You build the new app once and publish it. Everyone using YaapZone then sees *"YaapZone 1.2.0 is available"* (as a notification, and in the app), taps **Update**, then **Install**. You never send APK files to people by hand again.

Step 1 · Decide what kind of release it is

What changed	Kind	Version becomes	Command (Step 2)
Only fixes (something was broken)	Patch	1.1.0 → 1.1.1	npm run release:patch
New features	Minor	1.1.1 → 1.2.0	npm run release:minor
Big change, or old apps can no longer work	Major	1.2.0 → 2.0.0	npm run release:major

Step 2 · Raise the version number

Every release must have a new, higher number, or phones refuse to install it. This one command updates it everywhere.

TYPE THIS (PowerShell)

```
cd E:\Preperation\chat-app\mobile
npm run release:minor
```

YOU SHOULD SEE

```
YaapZone 1.1.0 -> 1.2.0 (android versionCode 10200)
```

Step 3 · Save the code and put the server live

Ask Claude: **"commit and push"**. If this release changes the database, run the database change on Aiven **first**. Then open the Render dashboard and wait until the newest deploy shows **Live** (a few minutes).

Step 4 · Build the app file (APK)

Ask Claude: **"build the release APK"**. It takes 4 to 15 minutes. Claude checks the result and tells you when it is ready. The file is saved at:

YOU SHOULD SEE

```
E:\Preperation\chat-app\mobile\android\app\build\outputs\apk\release\app-release.apk
```

Step 5 · Publish it to everyone

Go back to the main folder and publish. Write the notes for your users, in plain words: they appear in the update dialog. Add **--mandatory** at the end only if old versions must stop working (people then cannot skip the update).

TYPE THIS (PowerShell)

```
cd E:\Preperation\chat-app
node scripts/publish-release.js --notes "New: voice notes. Fixed: photos not loading"
```

YOU SHOULD SEE

```
publish-release: starting

>> YaapZone 1.2.0 (versionCode 10200)
  the APK is versionCode 10200: matches            <- the file is the right version

>> Uploading to GitHub Release v1.2.0 (Shyam9985/realtime-chat-app)
   ... upload progress ...                         <- the APK goes to GitHub

>> Publishing on https://realtime-chat-api-h237.onrender.com

OK: YaapZone 1.2.0 is published: https://github.com/.../yaapzone-1.2.0.apk
  "update available" was sent to 12 phone(s); everyone else sees it at their next start.
```

Step 6 · Check it on your own phone

Open YaapZone (or tap the "new version" notification). You should see *"YaapZone 1.2.0 is available"*. Tap **Update** → wait for the download → tap **Install**. Open **Profile**: the bottom line shows **YaapZone v1.2.0**. Done.

If something goes wrong

You see	What it means	What to do
ERROR: Say what is new	The notes are missing	Add --notes "..." with your text in quotes
ERROR: The APK is versionCode X, app.json says Y	The app file is an old build	Ask Claude to build the APK again (Step 4)
ERROR: No APK at ...	The app was not built yet	Do Step 4 first
ERROR: RELEASE_PUBLISH_KEY is not set	The release key is missing on this PC	Add it to the .env file (see the table below)
The server refused (403)	The key on this PC and on Render differ	Copy the same key to both places
The server refused (400) ... already published / not newer	This version number was used before	Never reuse a number: do Step 2 again (e.g. a patch), rebuild, publish
Upload worked, then the server step failed	Render was asleep or busy	Run the same command again, adding --skip-upload at the end
gh is not recognised	The GitHub tool is missing or signed out	Run: winget install GitHub.cli then gh auth login

Settings a release needs (set once, already done)

These live in settings files, not in the code. Values are secret: never share them, never put them in chat or screenshots.

Setting (key)	Where	What it is for
RELEASE_PUBLISH_KEY	PC: **.env** (main folder) Render: Environment	Proves the publish command is really you. **Must be the same value in both places.** Change it only if it leaks (make a new one, update both).
FIREBASE_SERVICE_ACCOUNT_FILE	PC: **.env** (path to the key file) Render: Environment = /etc/secrets/firebase-service-account.json	Lets the server send notifications, including “new version available”.
firebase-service-account.json	Render: Environment → Secret Files	The Firebase key file itself (on the PC: the downloaded file in the main folder; never committed).
EXPO_PUBLIC_API_URL	mobile/**.env.production**	The server address built into the app, and the server the publish command talks to.
GitHub sign-in	Your PC (gh auth login)	Lets the publish command upload the APK to GitHub Releases.

Golden rules. 1. Always raise the version (Step 2), even for a tiny fix. 2. Server first (Step 3), then publish (Step 5). 3. A published number is used up: to correct a mistake, release the next patch. 4. Use --mandatory only when old apps would break.